first three estates, who are termed 'twice-born' because they have undergone the caste initiation ceremony (*upanayana*) entitling them to wear the sacred thread, have the qualification (*adhikara*) to participate in the *Vedic* ritual religion. But in addition to the members of the lowest *Shudra-varna* there is the remainder of the population who are classified as 'outcaste' or 'untouchable'. Each estate, as well as the outcastes, consists of ***jatis*** that are the actual units of social organisation. Ideally you should only marry someone belonging to your own ***jati***. ***Jatis*** are tied to hereditary trades and professions, thus effectively guaranteeing employment for those born into them. While inequality is essential to the system, the hierarchical arrangement is cohesive rather than divisive. ***Jatis*** are interdependent; that is to say, in a non-monetary economy, a *Brahmin* might provide religious offices in exchange for goods and other services.

Jatis are natural kinds of beings: the word can mean 'birth' or 'biological species', as well as hereditary social grouping. It follows that there is no concept of humanity. Birth into a particular ***jati*** is determined by the quality of one's ***karma:*** the accumulated consequences of good and bad deeds performed in an infinite series of past lives. The hierarchy is ordered by considerations of spiritual purity. *Brahmins* keep their status at the top by strictly observing a vast catalogue of rules set down in the ***Dharma Shastras***. These rules apply to every aspect of life, and isolate the pure (*shuddha*) from the spiritually polluting or impure forces that are everywhere. The maintenance of purity involves keeping the company of other *Brahmins*, studying the *Vedic* literature, various daily and occasional religious rituals, and the avoidance of polluting physical contact with members of lower castes as far as possible.

Further reading: Dumont 1980; Sanderson 1985